



The Zune UI – a predecessor to the Metro UI

The user interface

Microsoft designed the Windows Phone user experience code named “Metro” as the key differentiator between this new generation of devices and the competition. To date, all smart phones, including Apple’s stunning and innovative iPhone, Google’s me-too Android, RIM’s business-oriented Blackberry, and others, have been designed to work like miniaturised PCs. That is, they run applications. And when you want to perform some common task such as make a phone call, view pictures, or check your schedule, you have to think in terms of the application you must run in order to accomplish that task.

Windows Phone does not work that way, and that’s exactly why it’s so exciting. Instead, Microsoft has engineered this new platform to work the way you do, with a set of integrated experiences that blend content from a variety of locations, putting what’s important to you right up front and center. We’ll dive into Metro, discovering how it works, of course, but also why it works the way it does. We’ll also take a quick spin around the Metro UI, exploring the various available hubs and apps, setting up the deeper explorations that occur later in the book. Once you’re done with this section, you should “get” Windows Phone: Not just the where and how, but the why.

There are many ways to describe and explain Metro, but perhaps the most obvious is to examine how Microsoft describes this user experience internally. Let’s see how Microsoft’s view of Metro stands in the harsh cold